

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Passing On Authority and Responsibility to a New Leader

The role of a Christian leader is to serve and endure difficulties for those they guide (Mark 10:35–45). For the apostle Paul, good leadership meant setting an example like Jesus Christ. Jesus's death on the cross was the most important thing to Paul, and it completely shaped how he lived his life. He said, "I want to know ... the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to Him in His death" (Philippians 3:10; see Colossians 1:24).

He meant more than emotional struggles or dealing with sin. He meant experiencing violent physical suffering. Paul endured difficulties for those with whom he shared the good news. He always made their salvation a priority over his own safety (2 Timothy 2:10; 2 Corinthians 4:8–12).

A Christian leader's life shows others about Jesus' death on the cross. It shows how God works powerfully even through weak human beings (2 Corinthians 12:8–10). It also shows God's wisdom despite human foolishness (1 Corinthians 1:18–31). When Paul called the apostle Timothy to lead, he also called him to "endure hardship" (2 Timothy 4:1–5; 1:8; 2:3; 4:5). Paul told Timothy not to be ashamed of the cross (1:8).

True Christian leadership must follow Jesus Christ's example of putting others first. When leaders focus on themselves instead of Christ, they fail to live out the good news of Jesus. A good leader follows Jesus's example by serving and caring for others, not seeking their own benefit (see Philippians 2:3–8). These leaders are ready to experience difficult times. They know that those who share in Jesus' death will also share in his life, and those who remain faithful through difficulties will share in his rule (2 Timothy 2:11–12).

Passages for Further Study

John 13:15; Acts 20:35; 2 Corinthians 4:8–12; Ephesians 5:2; Colossians 1:24; 1 Thessalonians 1:6–7; 2 Thessalonians 3:9; 1 Timothy 1:16; 4:12; 2 Timothy 1:8, 12; 2:3, 10–12; 4:1–5; Titus 2:7; Hebrews 6:12; 13:7; 1 Peter 2:21; 5:1–4

The Passover

The feast of Passover became a central part of Israelite religious practice. This festival celebrated God's rescue of the Hebrews from Egypt and his protection from the final deadly plague. God wanted it observed every

year, following the instructions in the book of Exodus (Exodus 12:1–27). Passover was a reminder for future generations of God's saving actions. All the people participated in the feast. They ate only unleavened bread, just as they did when they quickly left Egypt.

During the first Passover, they sacrificed a lamb to save the firstborn son of each Israelite family (Exodus 12:12–13, 23). Passover represents that we can escape death only through a sacrifice that substitutes for us. Passover was an important event in Israelite history. But the exodus from Egypt did not solve the universal problem of death, which comes from sin (1 Corinthians 15:56).

Many years later, during the Passover feast, Jesus Christ gave his "life as a ransom for many" (Matthew 20:28; Mark 10:45). He became "the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). While sharing a final Passover meal with his disciples, Jesus explained the symbolic meaning of the wine they shared: "This is My blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (Matthew 26:28). He represents and begins a new Passover. Jesus completely and finally defeated sin and death through his sacrifice (see also Isaiah 25:7–8).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 12:1–51; Leviticus 23:4–8; Numbers 9:1–14; Numbers 28:16–25; Deuteronomy 16:1–7; Matthew 26:17–30; Luke 22:15–20; 1 Corinthians 5:6–8

Paul's Role as an Apostle

To understand Paul's role as an apostle of Jesus Christ, a good place to read is the description in the second letter to the Corinthians. In this letter, Paul shares the core of his ministry. Paul was God's special messenger to establish and care for churches in the non-Jewish (gentiles) world. He served with seriousness and sincerity. His message dealt with life and death issues (2 Corinthians 2:15–17). As an early Christian missionary, he brought the good news about Jesus (the gospel) to places where people had not heard about Jesus (see Romans 15:20–21).

Paul's message of good news was plain and direct (see, for example, 2 Corinthians 5:1–21). He modeled it by his own life. He always intended to serve with truth and honesty (2:17; 4:2). As Paul shared the message of Christ, the self-sacrifice of Christ's cross was his pattern of service to others (11:16–33).

Some people questioned Paul's authority. So he shared how God called him to be an apostle and established his ministry in Corinth (2 Corinthians 10:12–18). Some wanted proof that Christ choose him and criticized

Paul's weaknesses (13:3). So, he pointed to the cross of Jesus and the lessons he learned from it (see 13:4; 4:10). Paul knew his own limitations and that he needed God's grace to do his work. An apostle's true authority shows itself in human weakness supported by God's strength (12:1-10).

Paul performed miraculous works to support his claim to apostleship (Hebrews 12:12). Yet, these works did not stop doubts among the young church at Corinth. Paul showed great patience in his ministry and did not give up when the Corinthians challenged him. This patience mirrors that of Jesus, who encountered much opposition from others (Hebrews 12:2-3).

Paul's example offers lessons for everyone involved in Christian service:

1. Christian leaders should regard criticism as an opportunity to evaluate themselves and check if any accusation is true.
2. Christian leaders should remain patient when encountering undeserved opposition and stay focused on their work.
3. It is important to provide a logical defense and explain one's motives, while also acknowledging that the Lord is the ultimate judge.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 10:5-42; 28:18-20; Mark 1:17; 2:14; 3:14-15; John 21:15-17; Acts 1:2-8, 20-26; 2:42-43; 4:33; 5:12; 6:2-4; 10:39-43; 14:3; Romans 1:5; 15:17-21; 1 Corinthians 4:8-13; 12:28-29; 2 Corinthians 2:17; 4:2; 6:3-12; 10:12-18; Ephesians 2:20; 3:4-5; 4:11-13; 1 Thessalonians 2:7-12

Persecution

Persecution refers to systematic mistreatment, harassment, or oppression of an individual or group because of their identity, beliefs, or practices. In religious contexts specifically, persecution involves the targeting of people for their religious faith or practices.

Persecution is a common experience for God's people. God's servants have often faced hostility and opposition (for example, Deuteronomy 30:7; 1 Kings 18:13; Nehemiah 4:1-3; Jeremiah 37:11-38:28; Matthew 23:34-37; Luke 11:49-51; 1 Thessalonians 2:14-16). Jesus himself faced persecution (Luke 4:28-30; John 5:16).

At the end of his earthly life, he suffered mocking, beating, and a terrible death by crucifixion. He told his disciples to expect similar treatment (Matthew 10:16-25; 24:9; Mark 13:9-13; Luke 21:12-17; John 16:2). He prepared his followers for these times, telling them

that the Holy Spirit would give them the courage they needed (Luke 12:11-12; 21:14-15; Acts 1:8).

The book of Acts describes how the earliest Christians faced persecution. It started with the Jewish high council's (Sanhedrin) hostility. Saul of Tarsus persecuted the early church before he met Jesus in a vision near Damascus (Acts 8:1-3; 9:1-13, 21; 22:4; 26:9-11; see 1 Corinthians 15:9; Galatians 1:13; Philippians 3:6). The apostles Peter, John, Stephen, James, Paul, and Barnabas all suffered persecution (Acts 4:15-18; 5:17-18; 7:54-60; 12:1-4; 14:5-6).

In his parable of the farmer and the seed, Jesus explained how persecution affects those with weak faith (Matthew 13:20-21; Mark 4:16-17). Persecution purifies God's people and helps them become more like Jesus. The apostles' experiences in the book of Acts support Paul's statement: "Indeed, all who desire to live godly lives in Christ Jesus will be persecuted" (2 Timothy 3:12; see Mark 10:29-30).

Jesus told his disciples to be ready to defend their faith in difficult situations (Matthew 10:18-20; Luke 21:12-15). The apostles and other leaders did this with courage and boldness (for example, Acts 4:8-12, 31; 5:29-32; 6:8-10; 8:4-40; 9:27). The Scriptures encourage Christians to defend their faith bravely and kindly. They must be able to explain their beliefs to those who ask questions (Colossians 4:6; 2 Timothy 2:24-25; 1 Peter 3:15).

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 18:2-15; 19:1-18; Nehemiah 4:1-3; Jeremiah 37:1-38:28; Matthew 10:16-39; 13:20-21; 23:34-38; 24:9-14; Mark 10:29-31; 13:9-13; Luke 11:47-51; 12:11-12; 21:12-19; John 16:1-4; Acts 4:13-31; 5:17-42; 6:8-8:4; 9:1-31; 12:1-19; 14:1-7; 22:3-29; 23:12-31; 26:9-11; Galatians 1:13; 1 Thessalonians 2:14-16; 2 Timothy 3:11-14; 1 Peter 3:13-18

The Plagues

The main purpose of the plagues in Egypt was not to rescue the Hebrew people from Egyptian oppression. If rescue was the goal, one big miracle would have been enough. The plagues intended to show who God is to Israel, Egypt, and nearby nations.

The Israelites likely forgot who God was. They lived for hundreds of years in Egypt, a culture that worshiped many false gods. Whatever they believed about God when they arrived, the Israelites became influenced by pagan views during their time there (see Exodus 32).

The plagues in the book of Exodus showed the Lord's complete power over all creation. These disasters

targeted elements that the Egyptians respected and worshiped:

1. The Nile Turned to Blood (7:14–25): The Nile River, seen as a god that provided life and fertility to Egypt, turned into a symbol of death.
2. Frogs (8:1–15): The Egyptians respected frogs, represented by Heqet, the frog-headed goddess of fertility. They thought she had the secret to life after death. Now, frogs covered the land, bringing the smell of death.
3. Gnats (8:16–19): “The finger of God” brought a plague of biting insects from the ground. This showed God’s power over Geb, the Egyptian god of the earth.
4. Flies (8:20–32): The Lord made a clear difference between Israel and Egypt. Swarms of biting flies filled the land and tormented the Egyptians, including Pharaoh. They revered flies as symbols of life from death.
5. Death of Livestock (9:1–7): The Egyptians saw cattle as holy, believing they controlled life and fertility. They depicted Amon-Re, Egypt’s chief god, as a bull. “The hand of the Lord” struck the cattle, showing his supreme power.
6. Festering Boils (9:8–12): God gave the Egyptians painful sores. The Egyptian goddess of healing, Sekhmet, could not help them.
7. Hail (9:13–35): The Egyptian god Osiris, who represented plants, could not stop the Lord from destroying them, because “the earth is the LORD’s.”
8. Locusts (10:1–20): The Lord sent wind to bring locusts, which destroyed the remaining plants. This ended any hope that Osiris could restore Egypt’s crops.
9. Darkness (10:21–29): The Lord showed total control over Re, the sun god and leader of the Egyptian gods, who was seen as the father of mankind. No power in Egypt could oppose the Lord and his plans.
10. Death of the Firstborn (11:1–12:30): The Lord took the life of each Egyptian family’s male heir, which they valued most. Meanwhile, the Lord saved Israel through the Passover blood sacrifice.

Yahweh showed both the Egyptians and the Israelites that he is the only God.

The plagues are often known as “signs,” similar to Jesus’ miracles (for example, Exodus 7:3; 10:1–2; John 2:23; 4:48; 12:37). The plagues demonstrate that worshipping created things leads to God’s judgment. In contrast, Jesus’ miracles show that God can conquer all deadly aspects of creation. This includes illness,

evil forces, unpredictable nature, and even death, through the gift of life.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 12:15–20; 20:1–18; Exodus 7:3–5; 7:14–11:10; 12:28–33; 32:35; Numbers 11:33; 12:1–15; 16:43–50; 1 Kings 13:4; 2 Kings 2:24; 2 Chronicles 26:16–21; Acts 5:1–11

The Poor and Needy in the Psalms

Throughout the Bible, God supports those who are poor and needy. These people are often oppressed and treated badly by society or greedy people. The book of Psalms frequently mentions the struggles of the oppressed and God’s concern for them. In their distress, the poor and needy can find refuge in the Lord (see Psalms 76:9; 107:4–9). They can call out to him, as he has promised to care for them (see 25:16–18; 70:1–5; 74:19). They can trust him and wait with hope for him to bring justice (18:1–50; 70:5).

Many people may experience life with sorrow (Psalms 88:13–15; 90:15; see 102:1–28). Distress can be a form of discipline that teaches righteousness (119:71, 75). No matter how long, severe, or what causes it, the Lord hears the cries of the poor, as many psalms show (10:17–18; 12:5; 22:24; 35:10; 109:31; 113:5–7; 140:12). In the end, God will satisfy the poor and the godly will rejoice (see 22:26; 132:15; 34:1–2; 69:32).

God chose the kings from David’s family line to bring justice to God’s suffering people (Psalm 72:2, 4, 12). But they did not succeed. Jesus, the Christ king, understands our human struggles (Isaiah 53:4, 7). He has come to help the poor and oppressed (Luke 4:17–21; see Isaiah 61:1–3). He is the hope for those who know they need him and who desire righteousness (Matthew 5:3–12).

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 9:18; 10:1–18; 12:5; 22:1–31; 34:1–22; 35:10; 37:14; 40:17; 41:1; 49:2; 68:10; 69:33; 70:5; 72:2–4, 12–13; 74:21; 82:3–4; 107:41; 109:16, 22, 31; 132:15; 140:12

Praise and Rejoicing in Luke–Acts

In Luke’s Gospel, those who receive God’s grace praise him for his wonderful acts (Luke 1:44, 46, 64, 68; 2:13, 38; 5:25–26; 7:16; 13:13; 17:15–18; 18:43; 19:37; 24:53). In the book of Acts, praise follows healings and the salvation of non-Jews (gentiles) (3:8–9; 4:21–22; Acts 11:18; 13:48; 21:19–20).

This theme of praise closely links to a key idea in Luke’s Gospel. The fulfillment of God’s promise through Jesus the Messiah brings joy. This idea appears early in the book in the songs of Mary and

Zechariah (Luke 1:46–55, 67–79). The Old Testament prophets predicted that creation would sing when God’s salvation arrived (see Isaiah 55:12).

When Jesus entered Jerusalem at the end of his ministry, his disciples shouted. They “began to praise God joyfully in a loud voice for all the miracles they had seen” (Luke 19:37). The Pharisees asked Jesus to silence his disciples. But he replied, “if they remain silent, the very stones will cry out” (19:37–40).

At the end of the book, the disciples “returned to Jerusalem with great joy, praising God continually in the temple” (24:52–53). The arrival of God’s marvelous salvation is a reason for joy and praise.

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 55:12; Luke 1:44–47, 64, 68; 2:13–14, 38; 5:25–26; 7:16; 13:13; 17:15–18; 18:43; 19:37–40; 24:51–53; Acts 2:47; 3:8–9; 4:21; 11:18; 13:48; 21:20

Praise Psalms

The Hebrew title of the book of Psalms means “Praises.” This idea fits many of the psalms. The psalms praise God for his nature and great acts in creation and history. People wrote praise psalms for both personal and community use.

Individual praise (Psalms 9; 18; 32; 34; 116; 138): In temple worship, people often gave thanks aloud in front of everyone when they made a vow or thank offering (see, for example, 22:22–26; 66:13–20; 116:17–19). These moments of personal praise and testimony added warmth and meaning to worship. Each rescue and experience of God’s mercy became part of the continuing story of salvation. Worship was more than just remembering God’s acts from the past.

Communal praise (Psalms 103, 113, 124, 129, 136): When the community gathered, they sang to praise the Lord for his historical acts (Psalm 103). Or they would praise him for a recent display of his mercy (Psalms 124, 129).

In Psalm 103, the psalmist praises God for his mercy to individuals and the entire community (verses 1–5, 6–14). Human weakness contrasts with God’s reliability (verses 15–18). His universal and absolute rule deserves praise from everyone and everything (verses 19–22).

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 9; 18; 32; 34; 46–48; 93; 96–99; 103; 113; 116; 124; 129; 136; 138

Prayers for Vengeance

Vengeance is punishment inflicted in return for a wrong suffered. It is the act of causing harm to someone as a response to harm they have caused. The writers of the psalms (called psalmists) sometimes asked God to punish their enemies. It was common for them to pray for the violent destruction of their enemies as a sign of God’s justice. How can this type of prayer be acceptable?

These prayers for the destruction of the evil people come from a desire for justice and trust in God. Psalm 1:6 explains divine justice. God protects the righteous and destroys evil people. The evil people are corrupt and committed to what is wrong. They oppose God and everything God does. They oppose morals, society, and God’s kingdom.

The psalmists argued that evil does not align with God’s nature. Removing evil is necessary for his kingdom to thrive. Yet, the poets of Israel did not call for God’s judgment on anyone they disliked. Instead, the psalmists followed God’s standards of justice and righteousness, which God expects all humans to follow.

The psalmists knew grief well. They suffered and experienced oppression from bullies, leaders, and kings both within and outside Israel. Their prayers were full of faith and hope. They questioned how long God would allow their suffering. They affirmed that only the Lord could save them from evil.

They deeply longed for his redemption. They asked God to make the wicked suffer as they had, following the principle of revenge (Psalm 5:10; 6:10; 7:9; 9:19–20; 28:4; 56:7; 104:35; 137:7–9; 139:19). Through these prayers for justice and salvation, the faithful can find peace as they wait for God’s rescue.

Do we truly see evil as evil, or do we think of it only as an inconvenience? It is right to pray for the end of evil as long as we recognize that God is the one who decides, judges, and carries out judgment. When we pray for God’s Kingdom to come, we are also asking for evil to be removed.

But now the harsh punishment that was meant for sinful people has been changed through Jesus Christ’s painful death on the cross. This action by God shows us how we should pray for those who oppose us. Jesus will indeed judge and bring a final end to evil (see Revelation 19:11–21). But while Christians wait for that final judgment, they are to love as Jesus loved (John 13:34). They should pray for their enemies and forgive them (Matthew 5:38–48; Colossians 3:13).

Passages for Further Study

2 Chronicles 24:22; Nehemiah 4:5; Psalms 3:7; 9:19–20; 10:15; 12:3; 41:10; 55:15; 69:22–28; 79:6; 109:6–20; 110:5–6; 137:1–9; Isaiah 61:2; Jeremiah 11:20–23; 18:19–23; 51:35; Lamentations 1:22; 3:64–66; Acts 1:20; Romans 11:9–10; Revelation 6:10

Preaching to a Tough Crowd

Sometimes God asks people to share the good news about Jesus with a difficult audience. The listeners might resist God's truth and reject both the message and the messenger. This was especially true for the Old Testament prophets, who often shared messages that people did not want to hear (see Jeremiah 26:7–9; 38:1–6; Amos 7:10–13).

The prophet Malachi preached to a difficult audience. His congregation included people who were:

- disappointed (Malachi 1:2)
- distrusting (1:7; 2:2)
- uncaring (2:13–16)
- dishonest (3:5)
- disinterested (3:14–15)
- doubting, skeptical, and the truly wicked (see 4:1)

What should a preacher say to such a group?

Malachi used conversation to engage his audience in a series of debates. The prophet gave a strong correction that cleverly answered the objections people might raise before they could speak. His message was powerful and made people pay attention: “those who feared the LORD spoke with one another, and the LORD listened and heard them” (Malachi 3:16).

Like the prophets, both Jesus and his followers shared messages with audiences who resisted them (see, for example, Luke 4:16–30; John 10:22–40; Acts 5:26–40; 22:30–23:10). Yet, this resistance did not stop them from fulfilling their God-given duty to share the good news about Jesus (see Acts 5:41–42). Those who preach the Lord's message can hope for a positive response like Malachi did. But, that is not always guaranteed.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 19:6–11; Exodus 17:1–13; Judges 9:1–21; 1 Kings 22:8–28; Jeremiah 28:1–17; Malachi 3:14–18; John 10:24–39; Acts 22:30–23:10

Pride and Humility

Pride is a feeling people naturally have when they succeed or achieve something. Many people in the world value being recognized and famous (see 1 John 2:16). However, pride comes from thinking too much

about yourself, and often leads to making others seem less important. The Bible often warns against pride and the harm it can cause. Instead, the Bible encourages people to be humble.

The book of Proverbs connects humility with wisdom (see Proverbs 11:2). Wisdom begins with revering or fearing the Lord (1:7). Wisdom recognizes God's power and importance. A humble person admits mistakes and accepts correction from others (10:17; 12:1). But pride can prevent learning from others. It can cause conflict (13:10). It leads to disgrace (11:2).

In the divine plan, pride leads to downfall and shame, while humility brings honor (Proverbs 11:2; 18:12; 29:23). People asked Jesus, “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” He indicated that the model was the pure humility of a child (Matthew 18:1–5).

In another story, Jesus shared a parable comparing the proud prayer of a religious leader with the humble prayer of a tax collector. He concluded with the words, “For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted” (Luke 18:9–14; see also Matthew 23:8–12; Luke 14:7–11).

Jesus showed the ultimate example of humility. Even though he is God's son, “he did not consider equality with God something to be grasped.” Instead, “taking the form of a servant,” he “became obedient to death—even death on a cross” (Philippians 2:6–8). God commands us to humble ourselves with the same self-sacrifice (Philippians 2:3–5; 1 John 3:16).

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 3:5–14; 2 Chronicles 26:14–20; Proverbs 10:17; 11:2; 12:15; 15:5; 22:4; 29:23; Matthew 5:5; 18:4; 21:5; Luke 18:9–14; Ephesians 4:2; Philippians 2:3; James 1:21; 3:13; 4:10

The Priestly Blessing

The priestly blessing is a well-known and beloved passage in the Hebrew Bible (Numbers 6:22–27). For centuries, worshipers have found comfort in its short yet meaningful lines. This famous text is simple and distinguished.

The priestly blessing calls for the Lord's favor by repeating his name in each request (“the Lord” means Yahweh; see study note on Exodus 3:15). Repeating God's name reminds his people of his care and role in their lives. This blessing emphasizes the bond between God and his people and helps them remember from where their blessings come.

Many Old Testament passages talk about blessings from God and people (for example, Genesis 12:1–3;

27:1–40; Deuteronomy 7:12–15; 28:1–14). The Israelites needed God’s blessings, his help and favor, as they prepared to leave Sinai. Modern readers often think of blessings in general terms. But, the Israelites in the wilderness understood them as food, water, health, children, protection from enemies, and settling in the promised land. Throughout the book of Numbers, God provided Israel’s practical needs.

The Lord blessed Israel through the words of Aaron and his sons, the priests (Numbers 6:22–23). Besides their work in the tabernacle (and later the temple), the priests played a key role in Israelite life. For example, the priests helped guarantee justice in the land (Deuteronomy 17:8–12). They supported the king in his duties, following a principle in Deuteronomy 17:18–20. Eli the priest comforted Hannah and guided young Samuel’s spiritual growth (1 Samuel 1:1–3:21). The priests and Levites were active in teaching Israel’s spiritual lessons (see, for example, Deuteronomy 33:9–10; Nehemiah 8:9–12; Malachi 2:5–9).

An important archaeological discovery emphasizes the importance of this ancient priestly blessing. In 1980, excavators found two small silver scrolls in a rock-cut tomb at Ketef Hinnom, southwest of Jerusalem’s Old City. Scholars date these objects (amulets) to the late 600s or early 500s BC. After a long and careful process, they unrolled the delicate scrolls and found the blessing from Numbers 6:24–26, closely matching the Hebrew Bible text.

In ancient times, people sometimes wore such scrolls as symbolic objects (charms), similar to tefillin or “phylacteries” or “prayer boxes” (see Deuteronomy 6:8; Matthew 23:5). These small scrolls are the earliest biblical manuscripts and contain the earliest reference to Yahweh, the Old Testament name of God, found in Jerusalem. These archaeological finds show the lasting appeal of this brief biblical text.

Many New Testament letters conclude with a blessing for the readers. This blessing is similar to the priestly blessing in Numbers (for example, 2 Corinthians 13:14; Hebrews 13:20–21).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:28; 9:1, 26–27; 12:1–3; 14:19–20; 28:1–4; 48:15–20; 49:25–26; Leviticus 9:22; Numbers 6:22–27; 24:1–9; Deuteronomy 10:8; 33:11–29; 1 Samuel 2:20; 1 Kings 8:55–65; 2 Chronicles 30:27; Psalms 115:12–15; 128:1–6; Matthew 5:3–11; Luke 11:27–28; 2 Corinthians 13:14; Ephesians 6:23; 1 Thessalonians 5:23–24

The Promise of a Second Exodus

God brought the people of Israel back to their homeland from Babylon, just as he had brought them out of Egypt many years before (Isaiah 48:20–21). (This first rescue from Egypt is called the exodus.) This time, when leaving Babylon, the people needed to be pure and take their time, not rushing to leave (52:11,12).

The experience in exile and the journey compare to a desert from which the Lord rescues (see Isaiah 35:1):

- He creates a road through the desert and turns it into a place with water, plants, and animals (Isaiah 43:19–20).
- He removes obstacles (42:16; 49:11).
- He guides his people (42:16; 58:11; 63:13).
- He feeds them (49:10).
- He protects them from the heat (49:10).
- He gives them strength (58:11).
- He changes their sorrow into great joy (51:3).
- He pours out his Spirit on them (44:3–4).

Christians also experience an “exodus.” They leave behind sin and death through Jesus’ death and resurrection. The Holy Spirit helps Christians have a new life. They serve God joyfully while waiting for his kingdom to fully arrive.

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 35:8–10; 42:14–16; 43:18–21; 44:3–4; 48:20–21; 49:9–12; 52:11–12; 58:8–12; Jeremiah 31:2–17; Joel 3:17–21; Luke 1:78–79; John 7:38; 15:19; 2 Corinthians 5:17; 6:17–18; Ephesians 5:8; Colossians 1:13; Hebrews 13:12–14; Revelation 7:16

The Promise of Dynasty

God promised King David that his family line would last forever (2 Samuel 7:11–16 and parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 17:9–14). Yet, the writer of Chronicles (called the Chronicler) lived when David’s family line seemed to have ended. Although David’s descendants continued, no descendant had been king since Judah’s exile to Babylon over 150 years earlier (see 1 Chronicles 3:1–24). This situation raised doubts about Israel’s future hope.

The Chronicler intended to show that God’s promise to David was unconditional and that his throne was indeed “secure forever.” Even the possibility of exile does not remove the hope of God’s promise of a royal family line. The promise would continue for a future time because a future descendant of David would inherit the throne (1 Chronicles 17:11).

The Chronicler did not directly write about the Messiah in the strict meaning of the term. He was not

mainly focused on the coming of a deliverer chosen by God. Instead, he hoped that kings from David's line would lead the covenant community again (the people of Israel who had a special agreement with God). The Chronicler encouraged the community to anticipate a new king who would improve Israel's condition.

The birth of Jesus, the Son of David, fulfilled the Chronicler's hope for Israel. Jesus met the Chronicler's expectation of a new king (see Matthew 1:1-17). His kingdom includes all nations (Isaiah 49:6). It extends "from sea to sea, and from the Euphrates to the ends of the earth" (Zechariah 9:10).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 49:8-12; 1 Chronicles 5:1-2; 17:1-15; 22:6-13; 28:4-7; Psalms 78:67-72; 132:11-12; Amos 9:11-12; Matthew 1:1-17; 22:41-46

The Promise of New Life

The resurrection is a key belief in Christianity. Without it, the Christian faith has no value (1 Corinthians 15:14). God promises that his people will share in this resurrection with Christ (Colossians 3:1). It is important to plainly understand the new life God promises us.

Ezekiel 37 might seem to suggest that everyone will resurrect with new bodies after death. Yet, the prophet Ezekiel is not asking, "Can human bones come back to life?" Ezekiel and his audience already knew about the possibility of resurrection from the miracles of Elijah and Elisha (1 Kings 17:17-24; 2 Kings 4:31-37; 13:20-21). Instead, Ezekiel is asking, "Can these bones live?" He is questioning if God can restore the nation of Judah since they are a stripped, broken apart, and dried-up nation.

At that time, the Babylonians had devastated Judah, destroyed the temple, and exiled many people to Babylon. The nation had lost its power, been broken politically, and was spiritually exhausted. Those still in Judah were a small group, only the poorest of the poor (see 2 Kings 25:8-12). Many believed there was no future for God's people. They said, "Our bones are dried up, and our hope has perished; we are cut off" (Ezekiel 37:11). The question was not whether God could revive them, but whether he would perform such a miracle for the dry bones representing Israel.

The prophet answered this question with a strong Yes! God would bring his people back to life by pouring out his Spirit, responding to the prophet's word. Their death because of their sins was real. But God would not leave them in the grave (see Psalm 16:10). Instead, he promised that in the future he would give his people life through his Spirit. He would transform them

into a new creation, a new Spirit-filled Israel. This new people of God would stand as a mighty army to serve the Lord.

God can bring back to life those who are physically or spiritually dead. He chooses to give new life to sinners who do not deserve it (see John 3:5-7; Ephesians 2:1-7). Those who suffer from sin also receive the new life God offers through his Spirit, both now and forever (see Romans 8:5-13; Colossians 3:1-11). He makes people, whom the world sees as beyond saving, acceptable to him through Christ (1 Corinthians 6:9-11). He also prepares them for meaningful work in his service (Ephesians 4:12-13; 6:11-18).

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 17:17-24; 2 Kings 4:31-37; 13:20-21; Psalm 16:10; Ezekiel 18:31; 37:1-28; 39:29; Matthew 22:31-32; Romans 8:11; 2 Corinthians 5:17

Promised Land

God gave the first man and woman the task of governing the earth and ruling over creation. This was to meet their needs and honor the creator (Genesis 1:28-30). But when humanity sinned, they became separated from God, each other, and the land on which they lived (3:17-19; see 4:3-16; compare 5:29).

God called Abram to follow him by faith and receive Canaan as a special homeland. This land was a promised place for his descendants as God's people (Genesis 12:1-3, 7; 13:14-18; 15:7-21; 17:7-8). Later, God freed Israel from slavery in Egypt. At Mount Sinai, he made a covenant (special agreement) with them to be his people. Then they received the land promised to their ancestors.

Keeping the land depended on obedience. If Israel violated the covenant, they would encounter its curses. The worst curse was exile from the promised land (Leviticus 26:32-33). This eventually happened because of Israel's continued rebellion against the Lord. He sent them into exile to Assyria and Babylon. They lost their land, and their enemies destroyed the temple of God (2 Kings 17:5-23; 25:1-21).

Yet, God also promises that when the people repent, "then I will remember My covenant ... and I will remember the land" (Leviticus 26:42). During the exile to Babylon, the prophet Jeremiah and other prophets saw God's future restoration of his people and their return to the land (Jeremiah 32:36-44). This happened during the rule of King Cyrus the Great of Persia (see the books of Ezra and Nehemiah).

The promises about the land still wait for their final fulfillment. God plans to prepare an eternal homeland for his people. In this homeland, God will rule directly and justly as king. Everyone and everything will follow God's will. Death and sin will no longer exist. The needs of God's people will be fully met (Hebrews 11:13–16; Revelation 21).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:28–30; 3:15–19; 4:3–16; 12:1–3, 7; 13:14–18; 15:1–21; 17:7–8; Exodus 6:1–13; Leviticus 26:1–46; 1 Kings 8:22–53; 9:1–9; 2 Kings 17:5–23; 25:1–21; Jeremiah 32:36–44; Hebrews 11:13–16; Revelation 21:1–27

Prophetic Sign Acts

The prophets of Israel sometimes used sign acts to share their messages. Sign acts were dramatic actions performed in public to make their message stronger. These visual demonstrations helped people not only hear the truth but also feel it deeply. The purpose of these actions was to create a message that people would not forget.

These acts were unusual and strange—not just to people today but also to people in ancient times. However, unlike people today (who might think the prophet had mental problems), people in ancient times understood that these sign acts were a normal way prophets communicated their messages.

The prophet Ezekiel often acted out his messages more than any other prophet. This was probably because he spoke to a very stubborn audience (Ezekiel 2:6–7). These actions emphasized his message and showed his deep commitment. For instance, he ate God's word (Ezekiel 2:8–3:3). Then Ezekiel demonstrated it to the exiles through a series of judgment scenes (Ezekiel 3:4–9; see also chapters 4–6). This dramatic communication is hard for even an angry audience to ignore or forget.

Jesus Christ performed the ultimate sign act on the cross (see Matthew 27:32–54). There, God showed his judgment against sin with darkness, an earthquake, and the suffering of his sinless Son who seemed abandoned by his Father. God also showed his deep love for the world by choosing to die rather than lose his people. The cross is a powerful message of God's love and judgment that is hard to ignore or forget.

Passages for Further Study

Jeremiah 13:1–11; 19:1–15; 25:15; Ezekiel 2:6–3:3; 3:4–9; 4:1–17; 5:1–6:14; 12:1–28; 21:19–23; 24:1–14, 16–27; 37:15–28; Hosea 1:2–9; 3:1–3; Matthew 26:26–28; 27:45–54; Mark

6:11; 11:12–21; Luke 22:17–20; Romans 6:3–5; 1 Corinthians 10:16–17; 11:23–32

Prophets in 1 Kings

A prophet is a person chosen by God to speak on God's behalf to people. Prophets receive special messages directly from God and then share these messages with others. God's prophets were important in the Old Testament kingdoms of Israel and Judah. They helped with daily needs, challenged kings and priests about their unfaithfulness, and performed many miracles. They shared God's future plans, especially messages of judgment (1 Kings 11:29–32; 17:1; 13:1–2; 20:42; 21:20–23; 22:20–22).

Several examples from 1 Kings show the role of prophets:

- The faithful prophet Nathan corrected King David about his sin with Bathsheba (2 Samuel 12:1–12). Nathan played a key role in stopping Adonijah from stealing David's rule (1 Kings 1:5–49).
- The prophet Ahijah told Jeroboam that God planned to divide Solomon's kingdom after his death (1 Kings 11:29–39). Later, God used an unnamed prophet to condemn Jeroboam's false religion and the altar at Bethel (13:1–10). He also showed the results of disobeying the Lord's command (13:11–32). Ahijah returned to announce the Lord's judgment against Jeroboam and his descendants (14:1–16).
- The prophet Jehu announced judgment on King Baasha because he continued to sin like Jeroboam (1 Kings 16:1–4).
- Much of 1 Kings focuses on the prophet Elijah (17:1–19:21; 21:17–28). He was God's main spokesman during King Ahab's rule (though other prophets were also active; see 20:38–43; 22:17–28).

In 1 Kings, the prophets received different reactions from the kings of Israel and Judah. The story shows the importance of listening to God's prophets and the risks of ignoring them. Through the prophets, God tried to stop the disasters that would come from the people's disobedience. Sadly, many kings did not listen to the prophets, leading to the prophesied destruction.

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 11:29–39; 13:1–32; 14:1–16; 16:2–4; 17:1–18:46; 19:1–21; 20:35–43; 21:17–28; 22:10–28; 2 Kings 17:13–15

Psalms of Suffering

The four psalms of suffering (Psalms 16, 22, 40, and 69) describe the intense distress experienced by God's servant. They are also called "Passion Psalms."

Psalm 22 uses some of the most powerful language about suffering in the psalms. In this psalm, God's servant suffers even though he is righteous. There is no mention of any sin, so the psalmist's suffering seems completely unfair. Despite being treated very badly, there is no prayer for revenge (see Psalm 137).

This psalm has important connections to Jesus' death on the cross (for example, Psalm 22:6–8, 14–18). In fact, Jesus quoted part of Psalm 22 while hanging on the cross (22:1; see Matthew 27:46). The sinless Christ even prayed for those who killed him (Luke 23:34).

Other psalms of suffering also became linked with Jesus. Psalm 16:10 anticipates Jesus' victory over death (see Acts 2:24–31). Psalm 40:6–8 suggests Jesus' selfless, redemptive work (Hebrews 10:5–10). Psalm 69 speaks of isolation because of commitment to God's cause (69:8–9). It also predicts the disciple Judas' role in God's work through Christ (69:25–26; see Psalm 109:8; Isaiah 53:10; Acts 1:20).

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 16; 22; 40; 69; 102; 109; Isaiah 42:1–9; 52:13–53:12; Matthew 27:46; Luke 23:34; Hebrews 10:5–10

Pure Worship

From the start of God's relationship with Israel, he provided ways for their worship of him to be pleasing to him (Exodus 20–40; Leviticus 1–8). One of the Lord's main goals for his people is to guarantee they offer him pure worship.

When King Solomon built the temple as a permanent place for worship, he carefully created “a house for the Name of the LORD my God” (1 Kings 5:3–5). He followed the given design, correctly placed the ark of the covenant in the inner holy place, and offered the temple to the Lord (8:1–11; see Deuteronomy 16:13–17). Solomon obeyed the law's rules (see, for example, Exodus 25:10–22). These rules intended to keep Israel's worship focused on the Lord and his commands.

People often worship based on their own desires instead of following God's instructions. Israel was no exception. In his later years, Solomon was unfaithful to the Lord by worshiping other gods (1 Kings 11:4–8). After Solomon died, Jeroboam created a rival, idol-worshiping religion in the northern kingdom. He plainly violated God's law (14:9–10, 15–16).

False worship was common in the northern kingdom throughout its history (for example, 1 Kings 15:26; 16:13, 25–26, 30–33; 21:25–26). Meanwhile, in the southern kingdom of Judah, local pagan altars were a con-

stant spiritual distraction (15:14; 22:43). Neither Judah nor Israel were faithful in their worship of the Lord.

There is one God, and his people must worship only him (1 Kings 8:23; see Deuteronomy 5:7, 9; 6:4; John 14:6; Acts 4:12). Our worship must come from a pure heart. We must stay completely faithful to the Lord in committed service to him (1 Kings 15:14; 17:1; see Deuteronomy 10:12, 20; Psalm 24:3–4; Matthew 4:10; John 4:24). In our daily and weekly worship of God we should feel his presence, bringing genuine joy (1 Kings 8:56; compare Psalm 63:1–3; Philippians 4:4).

Israel's temple was a holy place meant to attract all people to worship (1 Kings 8:41–43). So, Christians, who are the temple of the living God, should live in a way that attracts and motivates others to know the Lord and worship him (1 Corinthians 3:16–17; Matthew 5:16; Acts 2:40–47; 2 Timothy 4:5; 1 Peter 2:12). Our whole lives should include daily worship of Christ, recognizing him as Lord (1 Peter 3:15). We must not let any idol take God's place in our lives (1 John 5:21).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 8:20; Exodus 4:31; 25:10–22; Leviticus 1:1–8:36; Deuteronomy 5:7–9; 6:4–9; 10:12, 20; 16:13–17; 26:1–15; 1 Kings 5:3–5; Psalms 24:3–6; 51:1–19; Hosea 6:6; 14:1–2; Micah 6:6–8; Matthew 4:10; 5:16; 6:1–18; John 4:19–24; 5:23; 14:6; Acts 2:40–47; Romans 12:1–2; 1 Corinthians 3:16–17; 14:1–40; Philippians 3:3; Hebrews 10:1–25; 1 Peter 3:15; 1 John 5:21; Revelation 5:9–13; 15:3

Purim

The Feast of Purim is the only Old Testament feast not established during the time of Moses. Its name comes from a word meaning lots or dice (Hebrew *purim*, from Akkadian *puru*). In ancient times, people often cast *purim* to see if God approved of an action. A good number meant approval, while a bad number meant disapproval.

Near the king's throne room at Susa in Persia, archaeologists found a small four-sided object with numbers on each side. A similar die with the word *pur* dates back to the 800s BC. In the book of Esther, Persian astrologers used *purim* to decide the best time to attack the Jews (Esther 3:7).

On March 7, 473 BC, God saved his people from certain death, similar to the rescue from Egypt during Passover. Mordecai and Esther established an annual celebration to remember God's rescue for future generations (Esther 9:28). Later in history, Jews widely celebrated the feast (see 2 Maccabees 15:36; Josephus, *Antiquities* 11.6.13; possibly John 5:1).

When God saved his chosen people, the day intended for the destruction of the Jews became a day of their victory over their enemies. It was followed by celebration. Today, Jewish people fast and pray to remember how Queen Esther fasted before she bravely approached the king. This fast comes right before Purim, which happens on the fourteenth day of the month of Adar (in February or March).

During the joyful holiday of Purim, Jews read the story of Esther, loudly booing Haman and cheering for Mordecai. They enjoy special meals, exchange food gifts with friends, and give to people in need. Purim celebrates how God protected the Jewish people from harm and shows how God continues to watch over and care for his people throughout history (see also Genesis 45:5; Psalm 91; Proverbs 16:9, 33; Daniel 2:21; Acts 1:6–7; 2:22–23; 4:28–30; 17:24–27; Romans 8:28; 1 Peter 3:12).

Passages for Further Study

Esther 9:1–32; Psalms 37:23; 91:1–16; Proverbs 16:9, 33; Romans 8:28; 1 Peter 3:12

Purity and Identity

God is holy, and he made a covenant (special agreement) with Israel to establish a holy nation (Exodus 19:4–6; Leviticus 19:2). Being God's people meant Israel needed to be pure in worship and social relationships. God knew that if his people became part of the culture of their pagan neighbors, they would adopt evil worship practices (see Numbers 25:1–9). Their failure to stay pure and their blending with these cultures eventually led to their destruction and exile (2 Kings 17:5–23).

When the priest and scribe Ezra wrote to the Jews who had returned to Jerusalem, he intended to remind them to remain pure to their beliefs and commitments. After arriving in Jerusalem, Ezra discovered that the people had married pagan foreigners, which was against God's law (see Deuteronomy 7:3–4; Joshua 23:12–13). This threatened their identity as God's holy nation (Ezra 9:1–2).

The book of Ezra emphasizes the need to separate from foreigners. It recounts how those who first returned to Jerusalem refused to cooperate with the pagan people around them (Ezra 4:1–5). These people claimed to worship the same God but actually worshiped several gods in addition to the Lord. If the Jews had joined them, they would have compromised their beliefs and become ungodly, as Israel had before the exile to Babylon (see Exodus 34:15–16; 1 Kings 11:1–5; 2 Kings 16:3).

The early Jewish leaders in Judea understood the danger of tolerating these foreigners. They learned from their ancestors' experiences and refused to compromise the purity of their faith for the sake of so-called peace. They carefully followed God's instructions in everything they did (Ezra 3:2, 9; 6:18). To identify as "servants of the God of heaven and earth," they needed to please and serve him alone (5:11).

Today, Christians are God's holy people (1 Peter 2:9). This is a title that indicates purity. The apostle Paul advised the Corinthians not to marry non-Christians, as Christ and Satan have nothing "in common" (2 Corinthians 6:14–15). Righteousness and unrighteousness do not mix. God's people must avoid behavior that corrupts. Instead, they must adopt attitudes and actions that match their holy status (Colossians 3:5–15).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 27:46–28:5; Exodus 19:4–6; 34:15–16; Leviticus 19:2; Deuteronomy 7:3–4; Joshua 23:12–13; 1 Kings 11:1–5; Ezra 4:1–5; 5:11; 9:1–10:11; Malachi 2:15; 1 Corinthians 6:15–20; 2 Corinthians 6:14–18; 2 Timothy 2:21–22; 1 Peter 2:9–10

The Purpose of the Judgments

What is the purpose of God's judgments? Are they meant to bring redemption, or are they just meant to destroy? The judgments in the book of Revelation provide some clues.

At the end of the sixth trumpet, despite all the plagues, people "still did not repent of the works of their hands" (Revelation 9:20–21). Some people will not change, no matter what happens to them, even under pressure.

The tormented people of the fifth trumpet wanted to die instead of turning to God in repentance (9:6). Many choose death over admitting their sins.

In the sixth seal, the people asked the rocks to fall on them to hide them from "the wrath of the Lamb" (6:12–17). Their desire to escape judgment shows fear instead of trust in God.

Revelation emphasizes God's final justice and the idea of retribution or pay back (16:5–7). Both Christians and non-Christians will get what they deserve (see 2:23; 11:18; 14:13; 18:6; 20:12–13; 22:12).

The judgments are God's partial response to the prayers of the saints for justice. Judgment happens in God's time, not ours (6:9–11; 8:2–5).

The judgments, similar to the plagues on Egypt, show that earthly gods and God's enemies lack power (Exodus 7:8–12; 12:12; compare Revelation 13:4–17; 19:20–21; 20:9–10).

The judgments are part of God's mission and provide a final opportunity to repent (Revelation 14:6–7; see 9:20–21; 16:9, 11, 21).

God has made it clear that sin is wrong and judgment is coming (Romans 2:5–11). Yet, many people still refuse to repent and accept God's grace (Romans 1:32). Even in the final days, when God sends his witnesses to warn about the coming destruction, many will choose to support evil forces. They will celebrate the downfall of God's prophets (Revelation 11:3–10). Those who oppose God and turn away from him he will eventually remove from his presence.

Judgment for disobedience and evil actions is certain (see Romans 1:18–2:11). Yet God patiently waits for people to repent and offers his grace (see Romans 2:4; 2 Peter 3:8–10). Therefore, these warnings about judgment can be a chance for change.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 6:6; 12:12; Leviticus 26:25; 2 Kings 17:7–23; Psalm 103:6; Proverbs 16:11; Isaiah 13:11; 26:21; 59:18; Jeremiah 5:1–9; Ezekiel 11:21; 39:21–24; Zephaniah 1:12; Malachi 3:5; Luke 12:47; John 5:30; Romans 2:2–11; Hebrews 2:1–4; 10:29; Revelation 9:20–21

The Purpose of the Sinai Covenant

Almost everything the Israelites learned about ultimate reality from the Egyptians was incorrect. There are not many gods. There is only one God. The Creator is completely good, and evil comes from rebelling against him. You cannot gain God's blessings through magic or trying to influence God. God's blessings are free to those who lovingly submit to him.

When the Israelites left Egypt, they did not fully understand God as he intended. Through the plagues and crossing the Red Sea, they learned about God's unique power. In the wilderness, they discovered God's caring provision. Yet, they still did not know God's character. The covenant at Sinai was a special agreement between God and the Israelites. The covenant was designed to teach the Israelites about God's nature and character as they followed his Torah, his instructions.

The covenant used a well-known political form, the suzerain-vassal treaty. In this type of treaty, a powerful king (the suzerain) made a treaty with a nation he had conquered (the vassal people). The conquered

people promised complete loyalty to the king and agreed to follow his rules. In return, the king promised to care for them and protect them from enemies. In the covenant at Mount Sinai, God asked the people for complete loyalty to him as their only God. He wanted them to live in a way that showed his will and nature as their Creator and King.

God wanted the Israelites to simply obey him. Yet, since the first human sin, there has been a fundamental problem with the human spirit (Genesis 3). Simple obedience was impossible for the Israelites because their wills were not obedient. The covenant was good, but it could not enable the Israelites to follow it (Romans 7:12; 8:3). Without God's Spirit, we cannot do what we must or share the creator's character. But now, Jesus has died as a sacrifice on the cross to remove our sins. So, God empowers by the Spirit those who trust in Christ to fulfill his covenant purpose and share his holy character.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 9:1; 19:3–6; Leviticus 11:44–45; Jeremiah 31:33–34; 32:40; John 16:5–11; Romans 8:5–14; 10:8–17; Galatians 5